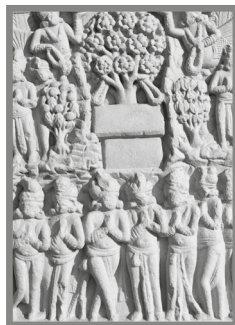


Buddha. He preached in northeast India and founded the Sangha—the monastic order of Buddhism—to continue his ministry.

For the next two to three centuries, Buddhism remained one among several minor sects but, under the Mauryan emperor Ashoka the Great (304–232 BCE), it became India's state religion. Ashoka's reign had proceeded initially through bloody conquest, but in around 261 BCE he had a change of heart. From then he embraced a new model of kingship and religious philosophy based on a creed of tolerance and nonviolence. He extended Mauryan control and, his Buddhism proving a powerful unifying force, succeeded in joining all of India, except the southern tip, into an empire of 30 million people.

A world religion

Having established Buddhism as the state religion, Ashoka founded monasteries, and sponsored scholarship. He sent Buddhist missionaries to every corner of the subcontinent and abroad as far as Greece, Syria, and Egypt. His missions established Buddhism initially as an elite pursuit, but the religion went on to take root at all levels of society in Sri Lanka, Southeast Asia, along the Silk Road in the



Stone reliefs depicting the life of Buddha decorate gateways of The Great Stupa at Sanchi, commissioned by the emperor Ashoka in the 3rd century BCE.

Indo-Greek kingdoms (in modern-day Pakistan and Afghanistan), and later in China, Japan, and Tibet. In India—its birthplace—Buddhism started to decline after Ashoka's death in 232 BCE, affected by a resurgence of Hinduism and then the arrival of Islam. Outside India, however, its tradition and scholarship flourished, evolving into multiple strands including Zen Buddhism, Theravada or Hinayana Buddhism, Mahayana Buddhism, and Vajrayana Buddhism.

The first religion to have spread widely beyond the society in which it originated—so the first “world religion”—Buddhism is also one of the oldest, having been practiced since the 6th century BCE. ■

The Buddha



The life history of Siddhartha Gautama is obscured by the myth and legend that has grown up around him. Different

traditions give different chronologies for his birth and death, but many agree on 563–483 BCE. Said to have been born miraculously through the side of his mother, Siddhartha was raised in luxury in the palace of his father, King Suddhodana Tharu, leader of the Shakya clan.

At the age of 29, Siddhartha rejected this luxurious life and left his wife and child, renouncing material things to seek enlightenment through asceticism. Having spent six years wandering and meditating, he achieved

enlightenment and became the Buddha, but instead of ascending to nirvana, the transcendent state that is the goal of Buddhism, he chose to remain and preach his new message, the *dharma*.

Gathering followers who formed the Sangha, a monastic order, the Buddha pursued his ministry until he died, at age 80. He urged his disciples to follow the *dharma*, instructing them: “All individual things pass away. Strive on, untiringly.”